

Farm and nonfarm family income in the Current Population Reports for 1956, 1960 and 1961

What the reports support. The three reports do not give one farm and nonfarm series across the five years. Between the 1956 and the 1960 income years the Bureau moved to the 1960 Census definition of a farm (page 13 of the 1960 report): a rural place of under 10 acres counts as a farm only with agricultural sales of 250 dollars or more, and a place of 10 acres or more with sales of 50 dollars or more. The report says the change cut the farm population aged 14 and over by about one fifth, and both later reports refuse to print farm or nonfarm figures for years before 1959 for that reason (footnote 1 to Table 17 of the 1960 report and to Table 19 of the 1961 report). The like for like comparison these reports allow therefore runs 1959 to 1961, and the 1956 residence detail has to be read under the 1950 Census definitions.

Comparable change, 1959 to 1961 (Table 19 of the 1961 report, families in households): the farm median rose from 2,799 to 3,238 dollars, 15.7 percent, and the nonfarm median from 5,619 to 5,930 dollars, 5.5 percent. The farm median stood at 50% of the nonfarm median in 1959 and 55% in 1961. The intermediate 1960 values are 2,876 and 5,813 dollars.

What not to report. Reading the rural farm median of Table 1 in the 1956 report (2,371 dollars) against the farm median of Table 1 in the 1961 report (3,241 dollars) gives a rise of 36.7 percent, but part of that is the definition change, which dropped low sales places out of the farm count. The farm family count fell from 4,908 thousand in 1956 to 3,490 thousand in 1960 and 1961, and the farm share of all families from 11.3 to 7.5 percent; neither figure separates the exodus from the reclassification. Under the old definition the 1956 farm median was 47% of the nonfarm median (2,375 against 5,061 dollars in Table 13 of the 1956 report).

The lined up table

The CSV carries every residence class the reports print: eleven classes for 1956 and 1960 (urban by size of place and rural) and the farm and nonfarm split for 1961, for families and for unrelated individuals, with the count, the full income distribution, the median and the year round full time worker figures, each cell marked printed, not available, or less than 0.1 as the page shows it. The 1960 and 1961 reports split 7,000 to 9,999 dollars into two brackets; the table carries the combined bracket to match 1956 and keeps the two halves as detail rows.

Nonfarm for 1956 and 1960 is not printed in Table 1, and the 1960 report gives no urban or rural nonfarm counts at all, so the urban and rural nonfarm columns cannot be weighted together for 1960. The table therefore derives nonfarm by taking the farm distribution out of the national one with the printed counts: 38,537 thousand families in 1956 and 41,945 thousand in 1960. Applied to 1961, where the report prints nonfarm, the same arithmetic reproduces the printed column within 0.1 of a percentage point, and for 1956 it agrees with the urban plus rural nonfarm weighting within 0.1 of a point. The derived nonfarm medians, by the Bureau's own linear interpolation (page 21 of the 1960 report), are about 5,051 dollars for 1956 and 5,799 dollars for 1960; they are estimates, not printed figures, and the households based series in Table 13 and Table 17 gives 5,061 and 5,813 dollars for the same years on a slightly narrower universe.

Other things not to take at face value

Alaska and Hawaii enter the figures with the 1959 income year. The household definition moved from the 1950 dwelling unit to the 1960 housing unit in 1960, which the Bureau judged too small to matter for family income. From the 1961 survey the Bureau imputed income for nonrespondents from similar households; earlier years rest on complete reporters only, and the Bureau's own test on 1958 data found the new method raises the upper income shares slightly. The 1961 medians in Table 1 (5,737 dollars) and Table 19 (5,744 dollars) differ because Table 19 covers families in households only.

The Bureau's present historical tables have since revised these years. Table F-7 carries 43,497 thousand families and a median of 4,780 dollars for 1956, 45,539 thousand and 5,620 dollars for 1960, and 46,418 thousand and 5,735 dollars for 1961, against 43,445 and 4,783, 45,435 and 5,620, and 46,341 and 5,737 in the reports; the counts for 1954 to 1961 were raised later and the 1947 to 1953 figures left as published; the footnote page that explains the revision is not in the folder, and the Bureau's methodology note dates the 1960 Census based population controls to

1962. The revised tables do not carry a residence split for these years, so the residence detail exists only in the contemporaneous reports.

The May 1955 release (No. 16) covers income of persons 14 and over for 1953 only. It has no family or residence tables and can be left aside; the modern persons tables already carry its headline medians.

The 1960 scan is bound out of order: pages 9 to 16 follow pages 17 to 24, which appear twice. Page 13, with the definitions, sits at PDF page 29.

	1956 (1950 def.)	1959	1960	1961
Farm median, families in households	2,375	2,799	2,876	3,238
Nonfarm median, families in households	5,061	5,619	5,813	5,930
All families, median (Table 1)	4,783	5,417	5,620	5,737
Farm families, thousands (Table 1)	4,908	n.p.	3,490	3,490
All families, thousands (Table 1)	43,445	45,062	45,435	46,341

n.p.: not printed in the reports in the package. Current dollars throughout.